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<https://github.com/crooksnwhiskey/project1>

Artist Statement

The purpose of our project is to display a message about the current state of the internet. We created a game similar to Pong to disguise this message and create an engaging activity. The user's primary objective is to try to continuously add to their score by using a moving platform to juggle a ball that is constantly bouncing around the walls in a set space. This seemingly innocent game reveals its ulterior motive about ten seconds in, when the player's movement is hijacked by a pop-up advertisement, hindering their ability to play the game until they close the pop-up. This mechanic is fully intentional and a direct response to how normalized pop-ups have become across the internet, as well as how they have adapted the business model of data collection. Our thoughts behind this were heavily influenced by Ethan Zuckerman's "The Internet's Original Sin". In the writing, Zuckerman reflects on how advertising became the "entire economic foundation of our industry"(Zuckerman, 2014), not because it was ideal, but because it was easy to do. The pop-up ad was then born from this logic. It was a workaround that solved a short-term problem and has now unknowingly altered the entire experience of the web. The idea of pop-ups and advertising being the new foundation led experts to conclude that "the entire economic foundation of our industry is rotten"(Ceglowski, 2014). Ceglowski argues that

because of this, users have developed a sense of immunity towards pop-up ads, saying that “the industry collapsed in a flurry of pop-overs, popunders, and shame” (Ceglowski, 2014). We tried to make this idea tangible by having no end to the pop-ups nor the score counter, making the experience mindless and droning for the user until they eventually tune out the pop-ups altogether.

Originally, we settled on making an air hockey game instead of a Pong-like one, but at a certain point, we hit a roadblock. After creating the rink, the puck, and the user, we realized that the actual interactivity of each part would be tougher than anticipated. The biggest challenges arose from the physics of the puck and constraining the user to the bounds of the rink. At first, we appended the user element inside the rink container and wrote a function that constantly checked whether the platform had crossed the bounds of the rink. If it did, the program would immediately force it back inside. While this technically did work, it created another problem. Due to the platform being able to still cross the boundaries, a jitter effect would blind the user while it constantly jumped back and forth. On top of that, if the jittery mess was left running for too long, it could cause a screen to get a burn-in, which we found out the hard way. Thankfully, the burn-in disappeared after only an hour or so; it not only became a wake-up call for us, but also forced us to redo our constraining logic. Instead of correcting the position after it had crossed, we redesigned the constraint logic to be mathematically limited before it reached the end, similar to the ‘constrain’ function given to us in [p5.js](#).

In addition to that, p5.js also gave us lots of physics, which we didn't realize until it was time to code the puck. We got to the point where we had to transfer the force from the user to the

puck and figure out which direction the puck should go. This was when we realized that making an air hockey game was just not feasible for us in vanilla JavaScript. Instead, we decided to change the whole game to be more like pong where there is no complicated physics involved. The creative process of this project ironically reflects the message of the final vision. In “The Internet’s Original Sin” by Ethan Zuckerman, the author speaks on the invention of the popup ad and frames it through the lens of unintended consequences, writing, “It’s obvious now that what we did was a fiasco, so let me remind you that what we wanted to do was something brave and noble” (Zuckerman, 2014). This is something that resonated with us because, much like the pop-up ad, we wanted to be ambitious and brave by making a more complicated game for a better user experience. However, this just led to annoying features and disappointment for the users.

The process of creating this final version was, overall, pretty enjoyable. The past attempt at making the air hockey game gave us a nice route to turn it into what it is now. After we obtained the basics, like the scoring system, ball movement and wall movement, we only needed to bring in a pop-up mechanic. This wasn't entirely too hard, but we had to explore new features that none of us had worked with before. This mainly consisted of interval timers, as well as making the game art on a website and importing it into a folder to be preloaded and used inside the game. Although this was pretty exciting to do, it did take a fair bit of time. The finished version utilizes if-statements to control the player's movement through a boolean, which is controlled by the timer that, every 10 seconds, makes the pop-up emerge on screen. This stops the player's movement until they click the pop-up. The pop-up boolean is turned on every time the pop-up is on-screen, and the boolean enables the movement of the player, so every time it's

‘true’, the movement if-statement turns off. This was the final feature that we needed to make the project complete.

The pop-up itself is pretty simple. The inspiration comes from the Reddit event, Place, talked about in the reading, When Pixels Collide. The event was an experiment to see how mass collaboration would look on one big canvas. Each user could pick between sixteen differently coloured pixels and place one anywhere on the canvas. They could place as many as they wanted, but there was a cooldown between placements, so a player could only place a pixel every couple of minutes. This event was amazing and was insanely interesting due to the volume of ideas it formed. This inspired the art style of the pop-up to be pixel art, as well as created the overall idea for this project. In the experiment, communities would get their work “hijacked” or experience what you could call a pop-up (someone putting something over their piece). The pop-ups that were made in ‘Place’ are very similar to what the pop-up is in the game that we created. Pop-ups are an issue that affects not only what Ceglowski proposes, but they also connect to surveillance capitalism as well. This is yet another reason why we incorporated it into the game: to consult a bigger issue or hint at something more serious. ACM labels this as ‘OBM’, or “online behavioural advertising”, and the harm it can cause is through “user restriction” (types of harm through OBA). By limiting the player’s interaction through pop-ups, it shows a theme of consumerism and surveillance capitalism. This is the “bigger picture” that we try to tell through the gameplay.

Overall, our project serves as a playable game that reflects the digital world where the user is second to the demands of advertising. By removing the ambition of a complex air hockey

game and instead creating a simpler, Pong-like experience, we highlight the "unintended consequences" that Zuckerman discusses. Just as the pop-up ad was born from a desire for convenience turned to a tool for "user restriction," our game's mechanics force the player into a state of mindless compliance. Our hope for the project is that during the users' play through, the interruptible interruptions and limitless score counter, they take the time to reflect on the "slow violence" of surveillance capitalism. Our game ends only when the player decides to stop, much like how the only way to escape the internet is to recognize the rotten foundation upon which it was built.

READINGS

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RESEARCH

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